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Paul Shaffer

Paul Shaffer has done it all! A pianist, composer, music director, author and actor, he is one of the most valued personalities in the entertainment business.

Paul was interviewed via Zoom on August 24, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

False start to 00:28

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Paul Shaffer with me this morning for the Fillius Jazz Archive. It's 11 AM-ish and that's about the time most musicians get their mojo working. Thanks for joining me.

PS: Yes. I cannot verify that my mojo is in fact working. However, if it is I certainly hope that it will work on you.

MR: All right. I wanted to tell you about a little research I did recently, sort of unscientific, but I've determined that in the United States there's approximately 3200 keyboard players who are somewhere between modestly envious or insanely jealous of Paul Shaffer's career and accomplishments.

PS: Well I don't, you know, I'm sure you're right because it's just been, you know I've been so blessed, that's all I can say, and talk about right place at the right time. I was. That's all I can say.

MR: You and I are of similar age and when I think back about the music in high school and so forth I remember how I was, so I'm going to take a shot here. Can you describe yourself at 15?

PS: 15 years old so I'm just trying to place what year I might have been in high school. At some point in high school. Tenth grade or something.

MR: Yeah tenth or eleventh grade.

PS: Yeah well I think I was already starting to play. Yeah, at 15 you know I was starting to play. I joined the Musicians Union I guess that's what I'm trying to say. Even up in Thunder Bay, Ontario, which at that time it was two towns in Northern Ontario, Fort William, Fort Arthur, me being from Fort William they amalgamated in 1967 and became Thunder Bay. But in Fort William we had a branch of the Local AF of M up there. I can't remember the number of the Local now, I should be ashamed of myself. But I sure remember the secretary, Rocky Albertini. And you went, I mean I was thinking about this today because I'm going up to Toronto to see this guy, a gentleman named Rick Lazar. I've known him since these days we're talking about when I was 15. I used to play the piano in school assemblies, I don't know if that's how I got started but

in what we call middle school here now, up there it was junior high (grades 7 or 8) I just made a decision, you know instead of playing a little piece by Mozart this time I'm going to play "Pipeline" by the Chantays. [scats] I had learned how to do all that on the piano.

MR: No kidding? You had the [scats] down in your left hand and all that?

PS: Yeah. Pretty easy to play it. It's a little Mozarty and if you think about it. [scats] But the [scats] I was just playing a piano gliss I guess but man it was close enough. And that may have been where I said well you know you don't have to write your own material at all, just do this. I kind of brought the house down because it was just so almost rebellious in nature. I don't know — it represented so many things. And from that point on, and then in high school you know I would do that, especially when The Beatles came out. And I was not one of these people we hear so many times of when I had a little interview show a little while ago, all these musicians, great respected guys, said the same thing. "When I saw The Beatles on 'The Ed Sullivan Show' you know that made me want to go —" well that wasn't the case with me. I was already digging earlier acts on Sullivan and they were so much more special to me up in Canada. But like when I saw The Four Seasons, that was, you know I barely noticed The Beatles. I was still reeling from The Four Seasons. So I played Beatles tunes nonetheless, you know they went over a little better than "Dawn Go Away" by The Four Seasons. And this guy Rick Lazar, older you know, one year more advanced than I, was more of a musical cat. Very hip you know, so hip his sax, tenor sax, always smelled of cigarette smoke. That's all I could tell you. And he caught me in one of these assemblies and said, "Let's get together." And I ended up joining the band that he was in and that's the long way around when I was gonna — so that kind of became my salvation up there. Otherwise I was a very, you know, nebbishy kid.

MR: I was going to ask if you negotiated the sometimes intense social atmosphere in high school because you had this persona. You weren't a jock or you weren't, I don't know you might have been a straight A student, but you had the music thing. Did that help you?

PS: Sure. I guess certainly it did, thinking back to high school days and stuff. But being in a band as it were wasn't quite the same up in Fort William, Ontario.

MR: Describe a gig for me up there.

PS: Well the gigs we were playing I was 15 going into 16 and stayed in this band until I graduated and left town to go to college. So a gig, you know we would play the school dances. That's really what we did, and then we had a regular Saturday night gig at the Fort William Gardens, a hockey arena where they would put plywood down on the ice and erect a stage and that's what we would play on a stage of about I don't know you know six feet high. Six, seven feet high up. A hockey arena. Booming sound. No such thing as stage monitors at that time. No such thing as roadies, that's the main thing.

organ and I would be loading it into my parents' car at the end of the night and it wasn't so glamorous as all of that.

MR: Do you remember what kind of bread were you making on the average hockey rink gig?

PS: 24 dollars perhaps a night. That was scale. Rocky Albertini specified.

MR: Oh so it was actually a union —

PS: Yes sir. That's why I had to join. I guess that's what sparked me thinking about Ricky Lazar you know. I joined his band, it was a union band. I had to join the union right away. Go down and see Rocky Albertini in the back of his shoe store, and he signed me up and I had to promise him, you know, "Don't be giving away too many of those appearances in the assemblies. I want to know about them when they ask you to play at the school, I want to be able to okay them or not." So I had to call Rocky Albertini, yes indeed. And then eventually both of us forgot about it. But yes that's how I started out, absolutely a union man which I have been all these years. And that was the scale.

MR: I'm sorry, there's a nice anecdote about you going to see Nat King Cole in Las Vegas?

PS: Okay. Well my parents were, you know my father a lawyer in this town of Thunder Bay doing all kinds of law, a specialist in civil litigation but he would do a will or an accident case you know, or even a criminal, whatever was going on. My mother a lovely housewife. Both of them very musical and totally interested in show business. And to talk about that "Ed Sullivan Show" it was a lifeline because besides the teenage acts that he presented, Ed had everybody that was anybody in show business and he made stars at that time, and we could see it on Canadian television, the CBC carried "The Ed Sullivan Show." So that was — Sunday night was, you know, family night around the TV and everyone in the business talks about it so nostalgically. Of course it wouldn't happen today. But Ed had something for everybody, whether it be all the old comics that I also became familiar with, the Shecky Greenes, the Myron Cohens and all of them.

MR: Topo Gigio?

PS: He had the little Italian mouse, you see how? Yeah, who could forget this. Senor Wences — a different guy, but he had yeah this thing. Boy that left an impact. And my parents took — they were very interested in Las Vegas, hearing about it, all, so many of these performers on television and on the talk shows Johnny Carson was our only talk show host at that time. We finally got cable TV from Duluth, Minnesota and were able to see Johnny Carson. And then, you know, Las Vegas, everybody seemed to be talking about it and especially Sinatra you know, my parents' favorite. Although my dad did turn me on to Ray Charles I must say, pretty hip for a lawyer in Northern Ontario. And then they took me as a 12-year-old kid to Las Vegas for a trip. But they didn't gamble at all. Barely put a quarter in the machine, just wanted to see the shows. And they took me to all the

went to but dinner shows, they had something they called the dinner show at that time and if there was anything risque about you know this show, a dinner show would be much milder in comparison. Kids were allowed to go because they served dinner — a technicality — and that's how I got to see Nat Cole with my parents. They took me to see him at the Flamingo. I'll never forget it.

MR: Why? It's an obvious question because of his musicianship, but I'm wondering if there was something beyond that that also caught your attention?

PS: Musicianship front and center, and he was on piano which he played quite extensively during the show. This is a main room show in Las Vegas. Spectacular lighting. It somehow impressed me as a kid but because his Vegas show was such that each song was like a vignette. And I remember he did "Miss Otis Regrets" — I'd never heard the song before but it stuck with me, I know it now, and he was under kind of a street lamp with a Sinatraesque raincoat over his shoulder singing "Miss Otis Regrets" "she is unable to lunch today" — so elegant and that made an impression on me. And then what he said, you know some of the dialogue I even remember word for word because he had a hit at the time on the rock & roll radio, "Rambling Rose."

MR: "Rambling Rose" yes.

PS: "Why you ramble heaven knows." I knew the song very well and his show, however, was more jazz than contemporary music. This would have been about '62 when we were there you know. And so who knows how he felt about "Rambling Rose" I don't know he sure sang the hell out of it, but when it was time for that he spoke to the audience and he said, "You know ladies and gentlemen at this time in the show a performer like myself would normally play what is currently and commonly referred to as his hit record but in some circles that would be referred to as milking the audience and you people have already been milked enough at the tables." And even as a 12-year-old I said I better get this down word for word.

MR: Yeah. You've got to get a shtick man. That's great. And I also read something about you playing for your parents, in a go-go dance apparently in the living room.

PS: Yes. I wrote about this I guess in my book and thank you it sounds like you researched a little bit. Thank you. Yes. That was the kind of nutty parents I had. Oh we want to have a go-go party and can you get us a go-go girl? We'll get a stage, a table that we can use for a stage and we want you to play piano all night and, you know, book a go-go girl for us. Somehow I was able to do that.

MR: That's a lot of repertoire for a night. Did it come from '60s AM radio?

PS: Their knowledge of go-go and such?

MR: Yes.

PS: Well I think they were more interested in the side of it, they might have read about Richard Burton's first wife Sybil, who had a famous disco in New York called Arthur in the society crowd. And they subscribed to the *New Yorker*, my parents up in Thunder Bay. They probably read more about Sybil and maybe the Peppermint Lounge, how they, you know, the society matrons were going there and twisting the night away and stuff. And they — you know — that was more, and the go-go girls and stuff they would have read about it more as a style thing. I was of course listening to AM radio and I could pick it up — American radio after dark by this quirky thing, everybody has a different explanation for it whether it be the Great Lakes carried it up or the satellite bouncing off — I don't — 50,000 watts of WLS-AM though did reach me up there after dark and I could hear the Chicagoland DJs and stuff and that was very influential too. So this was like me, you know, a nebbish of a kid if you will, and I could hear WLS at night and so I knew what the top three songs were in Chicagoland and I sort of felt connected in that way.

MR: Did you start to notice arrangements, the particular sound of a record and what gave it some distinction from the person behind that we rarely hear about, the cat that arranged the horns and chose the — you know we're going to put a harpsichord in here and all that. Did that seep into your consciousness?

PS: I don't think it did until much later. I was really, I mean I was hearing the records on the radio and zeroing in on them and certainly learning the arrangements because I was reproducing them on piano as a kid. Instead of practicing my piano lesson I'd start to hear these simple songs on the radio and find that I could play them all with just three and four chords just like a guitar-playing kid of today you know I learned those four chords and then I would also play the melody in my right hand, very simple but if I heard like an orchestration line for instance Gene Pitney I remember had a record that I loved called "Mecca" [sings] "I live on the West Side" and it had some oboe like a middle-eastern type of [scats] would come in and I would learn how to play that. And I'd really be reproducing the orchestration too. And that was kind of my, also what I did a lot of as a kid, and expanded my hearing and my hearing of chords that way. "Oh there's a fifth chord. What's that?" And it was as simple as that though, pretty easy to learn it step by step because the music was getting a little more sophisticated at a time. And then I guess really it wasn't 'til college when Blood, Sweat & Tears hit and they were very influential for me on the first album.

MR: Me too. I wanted to be Fred Lipsius.

PS: Yes. And you know I just made an album with him last week.

MR: Oh no kidding.

PS: Spent all day — not that I knew him but I know him now. He's been, you may know, a professor at Berklee all these years since then except he retired maybe four years ago, but still got it and lots of stories you can possibly imagine. But that started to hit me all of a sudden this horns, horns in rock & roll and how they opened up the stricture, you know the narrow strictures of rock & roll which were just you couldn't play more than four chords or we don't want to hear from you, and you certainly couldn't play a jazz solo like Lew Soloff did in "Spinning Wheel." And all of a sudden I started to see arranger credit, it was Lipsius or Dick Halligan.

MR: Halligan, yeah.

PS: And then I started to become a little more conscious of it, but it took that, it really did take that because I was just fine, in no way did I think I would ever become an arranger or a guy who, you know, can even call an arranger you know, at all. I went to college to study philosophy and sociology which is what you take when you don't know really what you're going to do. But the first weekend I was in Toronto for college a night club opened, you know a rock club and sure enough BS&T with their Canadian singer, David Clayton Thomas, and I was at all four shows just taking mental notes you know. Concentrating a little more on getting to see finally such world-class entertainment as that from Thunder Bay where I did open for the Troggs with my band but otherwise we didn't see too many of those kind of world class.

MR: Did the Troggs do the potato solo live?

PS: Absolutely. That's the sweet potato instrument you're talking about and the formal name is ocarina of course. [Scats] And it's one of those solos that I knew note for note and could reproduce for you even today.

MR: You were getting this amazing training for what you ended up doing in your career. Did, at some point when you were in college, did you decide I think I need to be a musician?

PS: Yes. And it was so clear because you know I had had this outlet, I had had this band, Ricky & The Fugitives, they were called The Fugitives and I joined them they were already a band. They were a sax instrumental band and played Johnny & The Hurricanes type material, Red River Rock, and Ricky could on that stinky tenor of his play the flutter-tongue style of that period and then they started singing when The Beatles hit and then they had to hire, they hired a keyboard player, you know they expanded their sound. What — I got carried away with my own boredom. What did you ask again?

MR: I think I was going towards some of the things you've said sounded like it seemed an inevitable —

PS: Oh yes all right, well in college I was so bored I gave up the band, I no longer was a member of the Fugitives or had any outlet to perform in any way and I was trying to be a

the time. Nowadays imagine, you know you have Epstein-Barr Syndrome, whatever it was I just knew that if I had a class at 9 AM 'til 10, by 10:15 I was back in bed in the dorm. I could not — so sad. And then I don't know if we have time and my old boss would say, "Do we have to cut away?"

MR: I've got time if you do.

PS: Have to do a commercial? All right well 'cause this is where the moment where I realized something had to change. First of all I didn't really go home for the summer after my first year at the University of Toronto because there was music happening in Toronto. I just had to stay. And I told my parents, of course I visited them at the beginning and the end of the summer but in the middle I said I would like to stay in Toronto and take a course in arranging. It was really that Blood, Sweat & Tears influence hipping me to the whole concept of arranging. "I'd like to take a course" and I knew I could sell them on this, just that word "course" that they were going to go for it and they did. They allowed me to stay in Toronto and it was very easy for me to get a job there in a bar band, live music in bars, which we had kind of the tail end of that scene that the Robbie Robertson and The Band came out of. I did that for the summer with some older guys and it's lucky I did take that course in arranging, it's the only real training I had in arranging. But, and it paid off. I certainly used it later on. I knew how to write a chart and did a little bit, even up in Toronto. So you know I may have been at some all-night jam session or something coming home late about 6 AM walking through — Toronto had its own Greenwich Village kind of place called Yorkville Village, and I walked by a guy at 6 AM sitting on a stoop in front of — he had a little deli grocery store kind of place, playing acoustic guitar, and I walked by him and then my ear caught what he was doing, I never heard anything like that, and I listened to him for a while. And he was a sort of a, you know we were all hippie styled looking guys at the time. He was a little Latin looking to me. And I said, "What are you doing? What the hell is that?" And he said, "Well are you a player?" And I said, "Well I play a little piano but I don't know anything about what you're doing and it's just so intriguing." And he said, "Well is there a piano?" I said, "Well over at the dorm you know, there's a practice room." We went over there, by now it's 8 AM and he starts to show me some things that really opened me up, my ears up, starting with standards, you know things that I knew through my parents and their love of music and jazz and stuff but I couldn't hear those kind of voicings at all. He immediately showed me a few things that started opening those things up to me. And then I started playing with him and apprenticing with him. And the second year of college I was now playing on the side with this guy, whose name was Michael Munoz. It turns out he was an American, he was from Brooklyn, kind of a street guy who played congas and percussion

into a bunch of open-minded musicians there, all of them in the Army, and he became a guitarist of this type that I'd never seen before or since really because he doesn't play any chords or harmonies or anything, he treats his guitar as if it were a saxophone and he were John Coltrane. And I'm still playing with him today because he and I have both — you know I came to the U.S., he returned to the U.S. after some time in Toronto and we hooked up again here and I'm right in the middle now of doing a record with him now. He's still so original he now uses a spiritualistic type of first name Tisziji Munoz but the Munoz is still there. He can be heard on YouTube and stuff and this record we're making together pretty soon. Still you know the most open kind of guy. And after he started me on standards in that little practice room at the dorm then he said, "Okay now we're not going to play changes at all anymore, just one chord, let's go." And he started training me how to kind of accompany him in sort of Coltranesque explorations. And he was kind of strict too this guy. He trained me how to really listen. Listen to him. Play what he's indicating. If I spaced he could tell immediately, I would hear his frustration. Just [wails] and I knew, I tried to avoid that at all costs. So that was the kind of training I got from this guy and when I started to play with him in the second year I cheered up and I didn't have to sleep anymore and it was just clear what I had to do.

MR: Oh what a fortuitous 6 AM walk for you.

PS: Yeah.

MR: And something you pointed out, that you were an apprentice, and that idea of having a mentor is not around as much as it used to be so it's fortunate that that happened for you.

PS: It sure is. And he continues to be a mentor this guy, fascinated by him. Now this latest record that we just recorded and we're kind of dealing with now at the stage of now how do we finish it exactly. But he's at the point now where we've got two great musicians. He said to me, "Get me, you know, instead of the guys I normally play with, who do you think I should play with?" And so I got the great Will Calhoun on drums who you may know from playing with the group now whose name escapes me. Excuse me? Yes. "Living Colour" spelled the Canadian way, C-O-L-O-U-R. Will Calhoun on drums and he said you've got to get Jamaaladeen Tacuma on bass, whom I was already familiar with. These two guys and Tisziji and myself, and Tisziji, there's no tunes anymore or no even discussion. He just starts to play and we start to play and that's how this album was done.

MR: Wow did it seem obvious that you needed to go to the United States eventually?

PS: Well yes. It seemed like a fantasy though, very difficult, I was aware, to do, to get the kind of credentials you needed to work legally in the U.S. as a Canadian. But it wasn't like it is today. Certainly we look at today's musical artists and we see that some of the

say more? And The Weeknd. Both Torontonians. It wasn't like, Celine Dion, my goodness, we look at some of the huge impactful artists. In my day we had Lightfoot, Gordon Lightfoot, The Guess Who.

MR: Joni Mitchell.

PS: Yes, thank you, certainly Joni Mitchell, yes. But she had her impact after she moved to Los Angeles and that, you know, I would never have done it on my own, come to the U.S. I certainly didn't come here and say here I am, you know, how do I get started. Again, it was just a series of crazy fortuitous — right place at the right time things that brought me here.

MR: I was trying to come up with my own description of Paul Shaffer, if someone asked me. And I didn't really do it except sort of a phrase like whatever comes up I can do it or I will learn to do it.

PS: Well you know to varying degrees of success of course. But certainly we learn that in show business. If somebody asks if you can do something you say yes and then learn how to do it. You can't always accomplish that. In my case you know I certainly, thanks to my mother who said that kid is going to take piano lessons when he's age six, when he starts to learn English in school, time for him to learn music and I did you know, and I didn't exactly practice, I was more concerned with practicing, you know, the stuff I heard on WLS by ear. But then I did start to just on my own realize it was related. The stuff I was learning, and then I got into a little theory. The Royal Conservatory of Music in Canada is a whole standardized thing, you have to take some theory and harmony too, and I started to see it worked you know and even The Beatles of course, they may not have been able to read music but they certainly could hear this kind of stuff that I was discovering too, and I could see they were related. So when I thought about going into music I thought well I would be in sort of a band, you know, Beatlesque in that they would probably work by ear. That's how I knew. I loved pop music. I was aware that a lot of it, bands and musicians worked out by ear. I thought a little more of that. But again, the crazy circumstance and I got into theater where they worked from the written page and that wasn't my forte. Sight reading still, can't really do it, but I can absolutely read music and I just need to woodshed it a little bit, and that's what I did when I got my first theatrical gig that eventually brought me to New York. I got sent the score, and I was able to well here I go, you know, sit down and learn it.

MR: Did you ever do a thing that — this is something I have to do at the piano if I get it — I have to chordalize it. I have to look at what's written and say oh well this is mostly a G chord here and etcetera.

PS: Yeah. I'm going to start doing that. I don't necessarily do that. I mean over the years and

to read enough, and to sight read enough to get through most dates, especially, certainly the treble clef, treble staff, and as much of the left hand as I could grab, and figuring out that there's going to be a bass and two other bones — trombones on that. You know what? I don't have to hit — you know some things like that. And I will still, I hate to admit it, but I will write in the ledger lines because that's just what I have to do. A-C-E. But at the time it's nice to see oh E and then bang I have it. And that's the way I kind of learned I could get through sessions. But really they wanted, I think I got going in the studios 'cause I really did love pop and rock & roll and I was not condescending to play it, I was dying to play it. The previous generation were kind of older guys didn't really like it. Sure they could play it but there's a difference than if you really love it.

MR: Yeah.

PS: With your own licks and stuff.

MR: Bucky Pizzarelli said, especially with the drummer, he said once you've got the straight eighth note down you were in. I loved that.

PS: Ah. Well there you go, yeah. But you know Bucky, did he know, could he play "Dawn Go Away" by the Four Seasons by ear? I don't think so. He wouldn't want to. I think that's more my —

MR: But he learned to and he and his cohorts.

PS: Well Bucky of course, he played on the classic dates of course. Classic rock & roll dates. I'm aware of that. But yeah so that was a great transition but as you know, and I've learned because I kind of became a freak for this stuff but that great combination of some guys playing in straight eighths, other guys still swinging and adding the swing to these straight eight rock & roll records and there was the magic that made people want to dance.

MR: There's a Chuck Berry record like that, that it's almost like you can hear half the band doing one thing and the other half —

PS: I think most of Chuck's stuff — well I think that's the prime example of it of course. Those Chuck Berry things, because that was rock & roll. Keith Richards likes to explain you know it had both elements. Today they've lost the roll. Everybody rocks in the straight eighth but Keith anyway refers to the swinging part of it and, you know, the bass player is swinging I would say in those, and the drummer is playing straight eighths and the piano player, Johnnie Johnson, who again this Keith Richards, another guy who has studied this stuff, he says well he was the real leader of the band. Johnnie Johnson. You know how I can tell? Because they were all in flat keys, they weren't in guitar keys, these great things, "Roll Over Beethoven" and stuff. It was Johnnie's band and he was definitely swinging — no he was both you know. When he would solo —

PS: [Scats] and yet didn't — so I'm fascinated by that now here in my older age, just what you stumbled upon.

MR: I should fast forward a little bit. When you got into the SNL band and were there for a while, did the writers start to recognize that you would be a useful character in skits? Like the Star Wars thing on the train? How did that occur?

PS: Well I was sort of sizing things up and saying to myself how can I get on camera. You know it totally was. Whether it was subconscious or whether I knew what I was doing or not, that's just the kind of kid I was, kind of repressed I guess on the outside but dying to break out. And well a couple of crazy things happened. The first year, no even before you know my first job in town was a Broadway show, "The Magic Show." Steven Schwartz, the Broadway composer, brought me in to town. Because I had played "Godspell" for him up in Toronto and now here I am, he moved me to New York and got me my first visa etcetera. And while that was happening one of these "Godspell" types, actor types got me an audition and I ended up going to Hollywood and making a TV pilot, which was unsuccessful at the time, and then SNL started. That was because where there was Canadians involved I knew Howard Shore, the bandleader from Toronto. After "Godspell" I met him on the next show I did — I was kind of theatrical up there, dealing with music, written music that I never thought I would but you know learning how to negotiate a chart, even if I couldn't make all the notes within the bar. I certainly knew the sign goes back to here and you know things that are still important. And whatever the question was it's long gone.

MR: Well you found yourself on camera in part of —

PS: Oh yeah how'd I get on camera. Well yeah so I left, they took that pilot off the shelf and I ended up leaving SNL in the second season and going to Hollywood and making a show that played called "Year at the Top" it didn't get picked up, came back got my old job back. But now I had some ammunition. I had seen this guy Don Kirchner. He had a show at the time, "Don Kirchner's Rock Concert." He emceed it in a really funny deadpan way. I am now back at SNL kind of participating in writing sessions. And Brian Doyle Murray, Billy's brother, had this idea — Brian Doyle Murray, a writer and a good friend of mine because he had been in Toronto, another whole story. But he said, "I've got this idea, Garret Morris, the only black guy on the cast at that time, what if he's in drag as Tina Turner and he sings "Proud Mary" which he did a bang-up job of in high heels. But we've got to explain it's like instead of he's Tina Turner but instead of Ike it's Mr. Mike, one of our running characters. It's Mr. Mike and Tina Turner. How can we set this up and so the audience understands it before Garret comes out in those heels? And I just said, "Well I could do the guy Don Kirchner who has that show. I happened to have worked

with him, you know, and I can do an impression of him." And he said, "Great." And that's how I sneaked on the air for the first time.

MR: Nice.

PS: Long story.

MR: But your hipness, the camera liked you.

PS: You know another crazy thing I did that I still can't really explain but while I was in Hollywood doing that show, the show was kind of about rock musicians. I play myself as a rock musician. And it would end with a musical number every episode. And for the musical number they wanted to kind of flash me up a little bit and they said, "Let's get you the wardrobe gal, I'll take you on Sunset Boulevard and get a pair of frames that will work in the number." And this turned out to be where Elton John got his glasses when he was in Hollywood during the "Good-bye Yellow Brick Road" era. And they said to me, "Would you like to see, we've got Elton's next pair, we're just waiting for him to pick them up. Would you like to see them?" "Of course I would" and I was just such a big Elton fan, still am. And they brought me those white frames that he wore on that cover, I can't remember the album, it's that square, white glasses. And I said, "Well give me a pair of those." And I started wearing them and not only in that number but then all the time. And when I came back to SNL I still wore them, Elton John's glasses. They were his trademark not mine, but I guess it was kind of an homage or something. I liked him so much that when the camera would go on the band you'd see me with those glasses. And it kind of worked for me too. And it got me, I don't know, it just gave me a little bit of a visual persona at least. It's really Elton John's persona but I don't know, that's how much I liked him.

MR: And you still do.

PS: I sure do. And — well he doesn't wear the shades so much, the glasses so much anymore. Now I guess he's going back to them. You know I didn't do the hair thing though, that he did do. You've got to give me credit for that.

MR: You did a different hair thing.

PS: Yes.

MR: Was being live on SNL or Late Night, was it nerve wracking?

PS: Sure.

MR: Or did you get used to it?

PS: Well it was really exciting on SNL, how live it was. At the beginning totally nerve wracking. I couldn't believe it was going to happen during the rehearsals leading up to it. How complicated the production of the show was — I never had seen anything like it. The studio that seemed huge at the time, and they had so many different sets as they still

the different sets that they're going to use during the half hour, all at different points, and how are they going to go from here to here? Well the whole camera's like a big caravan drive down during the commercial to the other end. I said this is surreal but it certainly happened. And every time was pretty exciting because you know you don't get a second chance, period. You don't get a do-over. Nonetheless Letterman was really more spontaneous because yes you could do something over, we never did though in the first twelve years when we were on at 12:30 AM we never did anything — a lot of mistakes were just left in. Much cheaper that way and the audience kind of loved it. They saw when things went wrong they loved it and of course Dave Letterman became a pro at just reacting to anything that went wrong, and of course you wanted to leave it in. Some of us missed those days, leaving it in, because they did edit a little more as they went along. But you know doing it five times a week, yeah, you do finally get used to it, finally.

MR: I was going to ask if there was a "break glass in case of emergency" type protocol if you really had like a train wreck but it sounds like it just spontaneously fixed itself somehow.

PS: I had some train wrecks on in the early days for sure that I couldn't believe were on. They just went on, they just went by. Something crazy sticks in my mind though. Paul Simon making a rare TV appearance and he was going to sing with his acoustic guitar just on the panel with Dave, a beautiful song of his, "The Late, Great Johnny Ace" very nostalgic and wistful, kind of sad, sentimental. And it had a — it came to a point in the middle of it where it just got, you know, came to a slowed down pause as some of Paul Simon's music does, and then would pick up again but before it could pick up again our assistant director the late, great Pete Fatovich who had to keep things moving, pressed that applause button and the audience applauded dutifully, and Paul wasn't finished. Well we cut to commercial and I'm standing there saying, "Wait, wait, this is professional TV" but they just kept on, came back and Paul was just well I didn't get to finish it but that's the way it goes.

MR: You know I was able to talk to Al Chez who was on the band for a while. And he said 90 percent of the time you got it. When you didn't you learned the art of "I don't know what I'm doing but it sounds like I do."

PS: Sure. I think he sums it up beautifully there. You have to, I mean it's very exciting to live that way on a tightrope. And it's the only way to fly on Dave Letterman's show. He was truly as spontaneous as it looked. I don't know if anybody else really is. The little experience that I've had going on some of the other guys' shows, all of which I love for various reasons, but they do seem to rehearse these things. And then a guy drops in, you know, "Let's take it from when he drops in spontaneous." No Dave would never do that you know, just I don't want to pretend, you know if it happens it's happening. Let's shoot

was. And he made it that way, such that anything could happen. And no matter how prepared I was — oh I'm going to have to sneeze — no matter how prepared he could change it, you know, at the last minute. Sorry. Drop of a hat he could change the whole thing and you'd just have to swing with it of course and don't worry about those charts. Guys, luckily I had a secret mic, I could talk to the musicians.

MR: Oh and it was just in their ears?

PS: Yeah. "Forget the chart, he's changed the whole thing, we're gonna do —" you know, that's the way we would have to operate and it kept it a lot of fun, really. It never got easy. It never got easy.

MR: When you had a guest like Renee Fleming, oh yow, speaking of learning on the job, was that a challenge? I think your buddy Tom "Bones" Malone related a story about how that occurred.

PS: Certainly it was challenging for me. Again when you're dealing with the written page, it's not my forte. Nonetheless I was having to run this thing, and luckily Tom was not booked and was able to write the key arrangements for me that we needed. But first of all it's Renee Fleming sings the Top Ten in some way. Now I can't quite remember whether it was special lyrics, our writer, who shall remain nameless right now although he did a marvelous job, but I said you know in a case like Renee Fleming let's see what songs she feels comfortable with changing the words to, and then let's write in our jokes after that. And this writer didn't think that was the way to go. He said, "No I have some choices here." Okay. So he actually wrote the ones that he wanted. And I then had to learn what he's done and the numbers ten through one different snatches of operas, well known operas, some more well known to this writer than to me I'll tell you that, but nonetheless it's only eight bars of each thing, and each one is hopefully a joke. That's the way the Top Ten is going to be structured. And Renee said can someone send me a tape of the phrasing so I know how to deliver these things if you're changing the lyrics. And so I made her that tape, happy to sing the stuff myself you know, as I would — oh I'm getting a call — you know I have — I just made three cents from this ringtone of "It's Raining Men."

MR: I was going to ask you about the residuals.

PS: Three cents at a time, believe me it mounts up. It's great. What were we talking about? I've gotten thrown off.

MR: Talking about Renee Fleming and you —

PS: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah, she mentioned it. She says, "I've got a tape of you singing those ten songs in full voice whatever that means. To me it was just really a day's work but then Tom was able to take my tape and arrange it and he did a beautiful job and we brought in

place where you just make one call and they're there at 10 AM. Renee Fleming came into my dressing room, we had our little woodwind ensemble Chez — I don't know if Chez was with us on that day or not anymore, but parts for everybody thanks to Tom, who stayed up all night writing these things, and then Renee making sure that she could time them right. Because it's got to be camera goes back to Dave, he says, "Number seven" bang back to Renee who is now singing it. So really when he's saying "Number seven" I'm going to be counting off the next thing and she said right, go ahead. You know. She was right on top of it and I don't know who else could have done it really besides her. So it was quite gratifying by the end of it but certainly yes, challenging given my shortcomings when it comes to the written page especially. Because she could say in bar seven, "Paul, what is this in bar seven?" You know?

MR: Right.

PS: And I was just, "Tom —" I've learned how to, you know, just go to someone else.

MR: I watched this morning on YouTube the scene with Sonny & Cher. And I just couldn't help but put myself in your place because I pictured you — "Oh they might do this song, I've got to have an oboe sound for one thing"

PS: Right.

MR: And it seemed spontaneous but I suspect that you were sort of prepared for it.

PS: We were prepared for the possibility of it. Cher was pretending that she didn't want to do it, but you know it was a pretty good possibility. Nonetheless our focus was on her number. She had a rock number, climbing the charts at the time and wanted to play that. She made a rock resurgence right at this time. It may have been [sings] "I have found someone" that song. [sings] "To take away the loneliness." It could have been that one. So we did that and we had time within about fifty minutes — 5-0 — that we have to get the mix right and stuff. And then after she left the stage I said let's run through, "I Got You Babe" — very possibly. You know. They'd probably do it. And I just happened to, I have the same two synthesizers, antiques really, for the whole run because I just didn't have the time to learn something new but I just knew I could get an oboe right out of my OBX-A and a harpsichord down here on the Kurzweil and I'm all set. You know. And so, and everybody kind of knew it too.

MR: Including the modulation which you did very well.

PS: Right from the record you know. You've got to do that. But it sure was fun that one, and I guess the last time they ever performed it together.

MR: Yes. And it was interesting, I was happy that near the end the camera panned over where we could see you and most of the band, and I got to watch your conducting style. You know you conduct with your head a lot.

MR: Hands are busy.

PS: Well even though you are piano conducting off Broadway style, piano conductors exist in the off Broadway scene. They don't have the — again the union. On Broadway you've got to have a conductor, who gets double scale or whatever, but off Broadway because budgets are more limited, and that's, you know even before "The Magic Show" I did one off Broadway show for Joe Papp in 1973. And you're piano conducting. So if you've got one hand free you can conduct with the other hand but sometimes it's got to be head, and certainly yes. And also you know in this case I'm watching them too. We haven't run it with them after all, we ran it once with the band, so I don't know when are they going to want it to stop. I'm just making sure, you know, "yes" bang. You know and then you have that going too. It's tremendously exciting when I look back on it, it really was.

MR: I guess. And when it finally got to the end you looked at the drummer, I guess it was Anton —

PS: Yeah.

MR: And you went like this —

PS: Oh yeah, yeah.

MR: And so he did.

PS: He gave some of that, yeah. Well they really had not been rehearsed.

MR: That's great.

PS: When we rehearsed it I certainly didn't rehearse an ending. I don't know what will happen, you know, just watch me. And then the audience is in and that was another thing about Dave, when it was 5:00 or something and the show tape's going to roll right at 5:30, the audience load in starts at 5. If I'm not finished with my, "Paul clear the stage, we've got to go." I said, "I just need another." "Get off!" That's the way it was so it also made it tremendously exciting. Sometimes we didn't have time even to learn the ending or something of a song and would go on in that position too. Crazy. Crazy. You get used to it on a daily basis.

MR: Did you have to audition for the role in "Spinal Tap"?

PS: No. Harry Shearer got me that role and just sold me to the other guys. And, 'cause we had been on the fifth year of SNL together, both of us having offices near each other and collaborated on some musical things. And we are friends to this day. And he just said, "Paul, this guy is funny and you should use him in this part" the local promo man. And they said okay. Rob bought it. And they all knew me to varying degrees. Chris more so, Chris Guest, he and I did early National Lampoon songs together, '74.

MR: Did the tape, did the scene take a lot of time to film?

PS: Oh. Well I did two days' work on this film. Some of my — my key scene really was cut

and this scene depended on it. Luckily on the DVD you can see it as a bonus scene. But they just sort of made an effort to leave me in as much as they could once they had cut my key scene. But between all my various scenes, one was in a record store that they did leave in, the in-store signing, and then some remnants of the one the night before where I have to talk them into going to a radio station and then we had to cut the radio station. Two days work on the film. All different — you know no written lines though. I said to Harry when he told me about it and I said, "So you'll send me my lines then." And he said, "You'll be making them up." And he meant it. There were scene outlines but no dialogue written. So in my case, you know just coming out for two days, I had to learn the various names of the characters and a lot of the backstories too, what's the president of the label Sir Ian you know and the different names that I would have to quote sometimes.

MR: Did you guys get that from Ahmet Ertegun from Atlantic Records, did you think that that was like an appropriate?

PS: Well I'm not sure, you know I'm not sure where they got Sir Ian.

MR: Sir Ian. Okay. I misunderstood.

PS: Yeah. Oh that's what I said, Sir Ian, yeah.

MR: Yeah.

PS: I think Tony Hendra, who was a British actor himself, played Sir Ian or whomever, and whenever they could they liked to get real British accents in.

MR: Well weren't you begging them to kick you in the butt?

PS: That's right, now kick my ass was my key scene in that, in store. The in-store records. A promo man, I was a promo man who was set up and in store but no one came. And not only that the records were all black, the covers. You couldn't see the black felt markers to sign them. Everything went wrong. And this guy has a meltdown, the promo man. And apparently it was based on a real promo man. And when these Spinal Tap members once had a comedy record out they had a promo man who did this, had a meltdown and said, "Kick my ass it's my fault." And so I knew, you know, this scene by when we got to the end of it that's where it has to go.

MR: You've been very generous with your time, Paul, and I wanted to mention just a couple of things in wrapping up. First of all I wanted to thank you for one of your World's Most Dangerous Band recordings because you chose "Cast Your Fate to the Wind" and "Yeh Yeh."

PS: Yes. Well they're right in my, you know you and I obviously same reference points.

MR: Yes. I can remember, this is not that uncommon but sometimes you hear the tunes, the cover versions of tunes first. When I heard "Cast Your Fate to the Wind" it was some

nameless thing like some nameless orchestra covering it, and so I always thought that was it.

PS: Well if I may, because I remember this and was alive then. It was way before your time, but whatever it was, '64 maybe, the hit version was this orchestral thing you're referring to. A nameless, you know a studio orchestra that they called Sounds Orchestral. That was the hit. To me, you're right, that was the hit. The composer was Vince Guaraldi, the great jazz pianist from San Francisco who wrote the score to the Peanuts stuff on TV. But he didn't have a hit on it. His version is interesting, a little more jazzy. It's got a jazz section that I don't think Sounds Orchestral used.

MR: Correct.

PS: Sounds Orchestral was a British, you know, British arranger who made up a name, Sounds Orchestral, and went into the studio. But to me that's the version. And I've learned it since I did "Shaggy" you may remember, I think, participated on that record. He transformed it too, did a marvelous job. But when I do have a little symphony show that I do once in a while when I can, and I do the Sounds Orchestral arrangement of that and I had a guy write all that piano stuff. I was able to, in my slow, and I can play all those licks now note for note.

MR: That's great.

PS: [Scats] Terrific.

MR: I love it. And I think I noticed that on Vince's recordings he did it in A flat and he also did the Charlie Brown iconic thing in A flat. Pardon?

PS: You're right. A flat.

MR: Yeah. I said he must like the flats I guess.

PS: I don't know the reaction of that but it reminds me of something a great story. I don't know if you've done Will Lee yet for your series.

MR: No I'd love to.

PS: Our long-time, as you know, long bassist on Letterman from start to finish but even before that you know he was a top studio guy. And during — there was a period of time I guess in the '90s where some records came out called "TV Tunes," versions of the great TV themes and stuff that you could buy on a vinyl record. This was in the days of vinyl, and you could get whether it was the Flintstones theme or the different themes to classic shows. And when they could afford it I think they used the originals but otherwise they would cut their own. And Will got me a date one time, after the show, "Paul, can you come and do a session after the show at 7 PM for this guy" you know. I said yes. And I'm there and they said, "We're doing the Charlie Brown theme," here it is, for the TV Tunes. And oh my God they've written it out, and I'm just — they expect me to read it. Luckily

I knew it a little bit, but I just, and nobody would get this kind of treatment in the studio but I was on television and a little bit I could ask. I just said to the guy [inaudible]

MR: Paul could you say that again because we had a little kerfuffle with our connection.

PS: They said we're doing the Charlie Brown theme and put out the music and I said, you know, taking advantage that I was a little known from Letterman, I said, "Can you just give me five minutes with the chart myself?" And it was an unusual request but he said, "Yeah sure, guys, take a five." And I just went to work with my pencil writing in the ledger lines and whatever I had to do [scats] and just figuring out the independence that you need [scats]. You've got to keep that going. Then you're in A flat. But under pressure, you know, I was able. So if you hear it, if you go like on YouTube I think, that's me playing that, me and Will, me under duress.

MR: Me under duress. Fantastic. I've so much enjoyed this conversation. Just to wrap up is it difficult in this music business currently to find a record label and promote your own recordings?

PS: I have no idea how it's done. You know absolutely no idea. Some say only the major artists can really make money these days with their recording work. And of course they make huge money. But otherwise no one makes money, it's all free. So I'm stymied. I don't know how it might work. That's the best I can do. I just don't know how people are making money except we know that, you know, somehow they charge exorbitant fees to go see them live, and say well we have to do this because we're not making money from our records anymore.

MR: Is it a challenge to gather your A Team for the World's Most Dangerous Band if you wanted to do a small tour?

PS: Well we did a tour, and Valerie Simpson came out with us as our special guest. Truthfully I never had to tour as opposed to pretty much all my friends. You know I started doing theater and then studio work and television and I find that traveling is just — it doesn't agree with me. The guys say, "I love the bus." "Are you crazy?" "No I'd much rather get back on that bus than sleep in a bed." You know going like that. And then the next morning at 6 AM the sun and you come out of the bus with your costume over your — to go into the motel. This is what you want? It didn't work for me. I assume though, you know Jimmy Fallon asked us to reunite and do one night with him when Questlove, his bandleader was, you know, in Hollywood being huge. But it was not a problem to get everybody including Will who flew in from the South of France to do this, and other guys, Aaron Heick on saxophone flew from the Caribbean or something. You know we were dying to play together again though, and it was a lot of fun.

MR: I'm going to close with two quotes, this first one is from Eugene Levy a/k/a Johnny Rose from the dream sequence in Schitt's Creek after you finish the swing version of "Silent Night" and Johnny Rose referring to you said, "He's worth every penny."

PS: Well that was in their prop — their plot of course, showing that they were so wealthy that they could afford the great Paul Shaffer if you will, for their party. It was a Christmas party. But God bless them I had to say well you know we've got to — so the point is they had me at their Christmas party before they lost all their money. I said, "But you've got to at least tell people who I am." "Oh no it'll just be great that you're there." Well you've got a lot more confidence in my stature. Tell the people who I am, and I think they ended up doing it.

MR: The last quote is something you said during a 2009 CBS interview. "I think I've done it you know, I missed Elvis, I missed Sinatra, but otherwise I did pretty well."

PS: Well someone had asked who do you wish you had gotten to play for. And I get asked still quite often, and that was my answer. But pretty much when I got to play for Aretha, you know that was huge for me. Momentous. Because I used to say wow if I ever got to play with Aretha Franklin. Once I knocked her off and got to play for her a number of times, even produce her doing "Respect" for the Blues Brothers sequel, then I said yeah I pretty much did it, Sinatra and Elvis. You know I missed them. But otherwise did pretty well. That's what I meant.

MR: Well this has been fantastic and I include myself in that group of envious musicians when we think about what you've accomplished and what you're still — by the way, like when we wrap up here do you have a musical task to take care of?

PS: Not today. No cats chomping at the bit today. But I make my own chores sometimes releasing what my beautiful assistant Olivia has certain Instagram mini-musicals. And sometimes, you know I get to flex my chops a little bit that way.

MR: Excellent. Well thank you very much for your time, and I hope to see you on the flip side.

PS: It's been a gas, your name is Monk, I don't think we have to say any more than that. Thank you, Monk, it's been a lot of fun.

MR: Thank you, Paul. Bye-bye.